

Earlier the top entrepreneur of your city used to reject you, now the top entrepreneur of the world is rejecting you. You definitely get better with convincing, but your conversion rate from reaching out to actually landing on a podcast improves but never truly gets easy.

Your episodes are long. How do you maintain energy?

Raj: Every episode, whether it goes out for one hour or four hours, is recorded for at least four to five hours without breaks. The reason why the guest doesn't get bored is I only do a podcast if I'm interested in the person or there's something to learn, or else I won't do it. So every year I pick up one skill which revolves around podcasting or conversation and I try to go deep down on it. Two years ago I learned negotiation, so I did all the classes, went to workshops, read like 10, 12 books on it. Last year I learned micro-expressions, and the year before that, the art of storytelling and movie making. This year I'm learning about breath, because my breath and the guest's breath actually decide how the podcast is going to be. Some guests are the top 0.1 per cent people in the world. If you bore them they'll walk out in 10 minutes, because they genuinely don't care about who you are. So you need to take your job very seriously.

How should a podcaster handle controversy?

Raj: If the gap between who you are in a private room versus who you are in the public domain, on camera, on podcast is very minimal, you don't end up actually being in a lot of controversies. Everything that I do is a micro deposit of trust in a public bank. If I do something bad the trust will withdraw, if I do something good the deposit will go up. One thing we follow very seriously is we keep our heads down and work, on good days and on bad days both. My entire team believes this – one podcast or one viral moment didn't make you, so one controversy or one bad podcast won't break you.

What does a successful episode mean to you?

Raj: I learn a lot from athletes. Do you know the concept of the failure equation? Michael Jordan – you know how many shots he has missed in his life? 12,000, and still he's the greatest athlete. Virat Kohli has scored a century in only 15 per cent of matches that he's ever played. So for us that number is five per cent – 4.93 per cent, to be exact. Out of 548 episodes, only 27 have crossed the big metric: more than 10 million views on long form. That is the failure equation for us. Are we ready to fail 95 times? If the answer is yes, you will have a successful episode. So the mental math for the entire team is: we need to create 100 episodes and we'll have five viral episodes.

Does India have the ecosystem to sustain up-and-coming podcasters, and what are the sustainable ways to earn?

Raj: We have definitely much lesser opportunities to monetise compared to some Western countries, because they have serious streaming money. Even after that, there are enough ways for you to sustain, because there's enough

money in the country. The biggest problem with a lot of podcasters or young creators is they don't know what they stand for. So how can a brand come to them? Just because you get x views doesn't mean anything. Are you providing a solution for a brand which is making a CMO's job easy? If I am somebody who loves gossiping, I need to show my personality as well – that I love gossiping while drinking a cola. Do that enough and you become really good for Coca-Cola to give you brand endorsements. Unfortunately or fortunately, in India the money is only brand money. Second, you need to build a business around it. Podcasting can't be an end – it is a means to an end, a marketing tool for you to go out and talk about the products or services that you have.

How important is video?

Raj: Very important. Video is the only way to make money. Audio money is only in Western countries, not in India, it's a very small amount. More concrete numbers: if we make five rupees from audio, we make 100 rupees from video – even at our scale.

Your advice for anyone starting a podcast in 2026?

Raj: First is, decide what are the things you will not do. Write down a list – I told you the five things that we don't do – and then do everything else. Have an "I am not going to do" list, not an "I have to do" list. Second is to be obsessed, genuinely obsessed, with something that you love. If you love technology and you're obsessed with it, only make podcasts in that. Third, don't take yourself seriously, and don't think anything will happen for at least the first three years and the first 100 episodes. If you are thinking for magic to happen before that, then you are in the wrong game. I see this game as a 10-year game minimum. We don't even think about returns or making money or making it really big until the 10-year mark. 

Getting the guest never gets easy for you. Never. Don't marry an ideology. That's one of the biggest problems that a lot of people have - I have this ideology and I'm only going to do this. And that's wrong, because every six months the world will tell you something else. The most important thing, where most people fail, is they compromise their value system.